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Infrastructure boost: Mallakhamb's debut at the 2024 Diu Beach Games sparked lasting change — a permanent training setup now stands at a school in Khanvel, Silvassa. SHASHISHEKHAR KASHYAP

From the margins to the mainstream

Khelo India Beach Games in Diu **elevates lesser-known sports,** showcasing untapped talent and shifting perceptions of beach sports as professional avenues in India.

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Manipur, a landlocked state, emerged victorious at the inaugural Khelo India Beach Games (KIBG), held on the Blue Flag-certified sands of Ghoghla Beach in Diu. Despite participating in only two disciplines, Manipur topped the table with five gold, six silver, and three bronze medals — four of the gold medals coming in the Pencak Silat event.

The KIBG featured six medal events: beach soccer, beach volleyball, Sepak Takraw, Pencak Silat, open water swimming, and beach kabaddi. Mallakhamb and tug

of war were included as demonstration sports. A last-minute addition saw a boxing ring replace the Mallakhamb poles to showcase the local boxing talent.

This wasn't the first time Diu hosted beach games. Last year's edition, held in January, was an independent initiative by the Union Territory (UT) of Dadra and Nagar Haveli and Daman and Diu (DNH & DD), with Madhya Pradesh — another landlocked state — winning. This year's Games were under the Khelo India banner, featuring 1,300 athletes from 31 states and union territories, up from 1,200 participants last year.

Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya hinted during the opening ceremony that Diu could become a permanent venue for the Beach Games. The move reflects the UT's growing ambition in promoting beach sports and boosting sports tourism.

Challenges and quick adjustments

It was only in March that the UT was told that it would host the KIBG. So, the Games came together in a short time. Arun Gupta, Director and Joint Secretary, Sports and Youth Affairs, DNH & DD, said, "Organising this edition wasn't a big challenge for us because we had the experience of